Social Experiments

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by Lost_in_the_mycelium

Summary

"Welcome to Coffeeland…" she runs through the spiel without any emotion this time. It's not like her supervisor cares about her delivery as long as she sticks to the script and isn't outwardly hostile.

"Are any of the winter specials fizzy?" the woman asks when she finishes.

Catra blinks. That's not a common follow up question. "No…? They're all coffee drinks."

The woman bounces on her heels, a trait Catra remembers finding endearing in someone else before she violently squashes that thought. "That's too bad. Can I please have a single shot of espresso and a vanilla cake pop?"

Catra walks around to the glass display and retrieves the dessert, placing it in a paper bag. She hands it over the counter and starts ringing up the customer. "Name for the order?"

"Entrapta," she says, then pauses to glance down at her name tag. "It's nice to meet you, Catra. How do you think you will die?"

AKA the fic that boldly asks: what if Princess Prom was a Coffeeshop AU?

Notes

This fic was written for the "Thank You, She-Ra" event for the season one prompt. Very grateful for this show and hope it

finds a new home where audiences can continue to easily discover and find joy in it. Either way, I'm very grateful for all the fans who will continue to keep it alive no matter what happens. <3

Catra groans internally when the bell rings and she looks up to see her two least favorite customers walk in. Ugh. She was *so* close to going on break, too.

"Welcome to Coffeeland. Can I interest you in one of our Winter Coffeeland specials today?" she says before rattling them off, her voice cloyingly sweet in a way that clearly means *fuck you*.

Adora looks disapproving, which is probably less about Catra's customer service and more about her overall presence in the fancy part of town where Adora lives now. From how she acts, you would think Catra getting a job at the cafe where Adora and her new rich friends like to hang out was an act of war.

Whatever. Adora can keep coming in all the time, looking disappointed when Catra is falsely polite enough to circle back to being rude, or sending burning stares across the cafe at Catra from whatever table she and her new sidekicks have occupied. Apparently the magical life of privilege she's living these days has caused Adora to forget that normal people *need* jobs, especially if they're saving up to go to college in the fall. Catra's goals are bigger than following Adora around just to fuck with her.

That doesn't mean she's above having some fun here and there as long as it doesn't risk her employment. And today the perfect opportunity has presented itself. As the duo order, Sparkles keeps unsubtly looking over at where the third member of their infamous squad is sitting.

Catra was surprised to see him come in without his usual bodyguards earlier, meeting her sarcastic smile with an irritatingly genuine one. Then he sat down with some blonde chick Catra vaguely recognized. Petunia or something? She always has fresh flowers in her hair, like she thinks she might accidentally trip through a time portal straight into Woodstock. Or maybe she just really hates people with hay fever.

Catra leans forward conspiratorially. "Don't they make the *cutest* couple?"

"They're not a couple," Glimmer hisses, keeping her shrill voice down for once so as not be overheard. "They're just…studying together!"

Catra snorts. "Oh, please. Everyone knows that's code. I work in a coffee shop, I know what a first date looks like. That girl's eyes have *not* been on their textbooks, and I don't think I've ever heard Bow laugh this much."

Practically on cue, Bow's laughter rings out. Every muscle in Glimmer's body appears to tense, as if it's taking her great effort not to run over and shove the willowy blonde aside. Catra smirks. "Doesn't seem like much studying is getting done to me. I don't know about you, but I smell love in the air."

Glimmer looks murderous.

"Ignore her," Adora hisses, red in the face as she herds Glimmer along toward the pick up counter.

"But if it's not a date, why didn't he invite us? We always study together!" Glimmer protests in a high-pitched butchery of a whisper.

Catra giggles to herself. It's so *easy* to get ~~Adora~~ those two riled up.

"You should just talk to him," Adora says.

"Oh, *now* you believe in direct communication over watching someone across a cafe?"

The door opens again, and Catra looks up to see a woman with long purple pigtails approaches the counter. Hopefully this will be her last customer before her break.

"Welcome to Coffeeland…" she runs through the spiel without any emotion this time. It's not like her supervisor cares about her delivery as long as she sticks to the script and isn't outwardly hostile.

"Are any of the winter specials fizzy?" the woman asks when she finishes.

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"Entrapta," she says, then pauses to glance down at her name tag. "It's nice to meet you, Catra. How do you think you will die?"

Catra freezes. "*Excuse* me?"

There's emotion in her voice this time.

"Do you have any theories about the potential cause of your inevitable death?" the woman rephrased, continuing to smile at her like this is a perfectly normal question to be asking.

"Are you threatening me?" Catra asks, more confused than alarmed.

"Not at all!" Entrapta says. "I'm attempting to stimulate conversation using research-tested prompts."

Catra considers that as she finishes punching in Entrapta's order. She reads off the total charge. "How do you think *you'll* die?"

Death is probably one of the topics she's banned from discussing with customers, but it’s not like she was paying attention in orientation. No one can blame her if the woman asked her *first*, right?

"Oh, that's easy!" Entrapta says brightly as she withdraws her wallet. "There is a statistically significant likelihood that I will die conducting one of my experiments. I have had many near misses already due to miscalculations, routine accidents, rogue machines, affectionate machines that don’t know their strength, and a few unintended explosions. Such is the price of the pursuit of *science*!"

Catra feels a genuine smile pulling at her mouth as she hands Entrapta her receipt and change. Adora is suddenly glaring again from the table where she and Sparkles are both doing an even worse job of pretending to study than Bouquet For Brains is doing as she eyes Crop Top's abs and arms.

Catra leans over the counter slightly, her smile widening. "I have a tendency to blow things up, too."

Entrapta's eyes light up and she looks eager to continue the conversation. Catra thinks she might actually enjoy that, but there's a line forming so she has to wave the human along.

After a couple more customers, she is finally free. She ditches her apron in the back, and ignores Scorpia's cheerful shout of "have a great break, buddy!" rather than wasting time correcting her that they aren't *buddies*. The woman had hired Catra less than five minutes into her interview, declaring that she just knew they were going to be best friends. Catra probably should have run in the other direction, but she hadn't exactly been having a lot of luck in her job search before that. The first time Adora came in and tried to interrogate Catra about why she was trespassing on her terf, Scorpia quickly intervened to wax poetically about their “special bond.” That only seemed to infuriate Adora more.

Catra plans to make a swift exit, but her eyes catch the espresso shot still on the pick up counter. It's distinctive for being in one of

the mini cups that are mostly used in orders for kids or dogs.

Catra quickly scans the cafe and spots Entrapta nervously hovering over Flower Girl's table. Arrow Boy is nowhere to be found, and when Catra glances around she catches sight of him through the front windows, having a tense conversation with Glimmer on the sidewalk. She has never seen Bow look agitated before, and the sight fills her with a giddy delight.

"How are you, Entrapta?" she hears Petal Power ask. Her voice is zen in a way that *probably* doesn't mean fuck off, but definitely feels less than genuine.

"Sub-optimal, but I plan to rectify my flagging energy with caffeine and sugar," Entrapta says. The blonde wrinkles her nose at that, but Entrapta doesn't seem to notice. "How are you?"

"I'm doing well, just enjoying some soothing herbal tea while I wait for Bow to return," she says. "I prefer to derive energy from restorative practices, such as daily yoga."

Her tone is very judgmental for someone who just admitted to spending four dollars on some hot water and dried up leaves.

Entrapta hums. "How do you think you're going to die?"

Leaf Girl's eye widen in obvious horror.

Catra can't watch this any more. She swipes the shot from the bar and crosses over the few feet to the table. "Here's your drink, cutie."

Adora's head whips around to face them, her gaze hard. What, now Catra *flirting* is suspicious? Sure, she has flirted with Sparkles to mess with her before, but it's not her go-to. Adora and Entrapta clearly aren't close since Catra has never seen her before, so why does Adora even care? Does she just think that any girl that lives in this zip code is out of her league? It wasn't enough to leave Catra behind, she has to keep finding new ways to make her feel —

Whatever. Entrapta is clearly crashing and burning, and Catra can at least try and make her look more desirable to *someone* in front of the girl she's trying to chat up. If it pisses Adora off for some reason, all the better.

Entrapta looks up in surprise. "Does this location provide table service now?"

"Thought I'd save you the trip to the counter," Catra says with a wink. She's sure it will go over this girl's head, but it clearly *isn't* missed by either of the blondes that are now staring at her. "I'm on my break now, if you want to hang out. I'll be over there."

Catra doesn't bother to look back as she leaves, Entrapta can take the out or not. She does sway her hips a bit more than usual in case…*anyone* is watching.

She curls up on one of the cushioned benches, clear across the cafe from the hopefully soon to be ex-best friend squad's drama and the two satellite women potentially being pulled into its orbit. Normally she wouldn't spend her break inside the cafe, *especially* with Adora's posse here. But the seating is admittedly cozy, and she can soak up some sun while people-watching (or bird-watching) through the window.

Entrapta wraps up her fumbling conversation and starts to make her way over. Adora looks almost like she's about to intercept her, but she’s distracted by a clearly distraught Glimmer returning to the table.

Entrapta grins brightly as she reaches the bench. "Hello again, Catra! Are you a scientist too? Or do you blow things up as a barista? I've read some of the statistics on espresso machine explosions, but I've never seen one!"

Catra is definitely *not* going to be looking up those statistics and clearly needs to change the subject quickly. "I mostly blow things up socially. Speaking of: Pansy, over there? *Not* the type of girl who is going to find questions about death charming."

"You mean…Perfuma?" Entrapta asks, before letting out a delighted gasp. "*Wait*, do you want to assist with my social experiment? I've identified this coffee shop as a common meeting place for my peers. It's the *perfect* environment to observe behavior. Your job would allow you to gather *so much data*!"

"So…you want me to help you spy on your crush?" Catra says slowly.

Entrapta blinks at her uncomprehendingly, as if *Catra's* the one who is using overly complicated euphemisms. "Crush?"

"Perfuma," Catra says, reluctantly using her correct name and everything.

"My interest in Perfuma isn't romantic," Entrapta says. "At least, I don't think so. I find romance…confusing. All relationships, really. But I'm currently focused on parsing friendship! I researched conversation topics empirically proven to build emotional intimacy and memorized the ones I liked the best. I even practiced in a low-stakes social interaction with a stranger whose opinion of me is inconsequential long-term, and who is paid to make pleasant conversation with customers."

Catra pretends to pout. "And here I thought we had something special."

"Yes, it was surprisingly effective at creating intimacy with you, despite the fact that we have no prior connection and our interaction was inherently transactional!" Entrapta says brightly, looking excited for a moment before wilting a bit. "Unfortunately, the results were not replicable. Perfuma has always been nice to me, so I hypothesized that she would be receptive to friendship. But I think I just made her uncomfortable…All the more reason I need to accumulate data specific to my peers!"

She already seems to be bouncing back by the end of her speech, but Catra still felt something sour in her stomach when Entrapta was describing her rejection. Why does some stupid holier-than-

thou blonde get to go around making people feel unwanted? "Look, you shouldn't try to pretend to be someone you're not for...*them*. I mean, how *dare* they pretend they're better than you, just because you're different? How dare they *abandon* people, just because they don't fit into their perfect little lives!"

Entrapta watches her outburst curiously. "My data is limited so far, but from what I have observed, their lives are not perfect. That would make for a very uninteresting study! For instance, Glimmer currently appears to be crying, which seems to be making Adora anxious as she attempts to comfort her. They're sitting separately from Bow and Perfuma, even though I thought they were friends. Social ties appear to be forming and breaking!"

Entrapta looks almost delighted by this turn of events, her eyes pinging around the tables.

Catra feels the fire of her anger cool. She had felt a familiar twisted pain cropping up for a moment there, but Entrapta's reactions are a good reminder that she could be sitting back and enjoying the chaos she has sown instead.

Entrapta continues to muse about the drama playing out in front of them—sometimes pulling out a recorder, as if silly teen angst needs to be preserved for posterity. Catra joins in with her own comments occasionally. It's nice. Usually, when Catra makes "observations" about Entrapta's peers, it just leads to Scorpia reminding her that disparaging clients goes against the employee code of conduct. And she wonders why Catra doesn't want to "bond" with her—shit talking customers is the basis of all great coworker relationships!

Much too quickly, Catra's phone alarm goes off, signaling the end of her break. She growls under her breath, silencing the alert. She swears she can feel blue eyes on the back of the neck and impulsively extends the phone to the girl next to her. "Put your number in. We can talk more when I'm not working. I can also introduce you to my…associate, Scorpia. I think you two would get along. *Don't* start off by asking her about death, though."

Entrapta beams, typing her number in with impressive speed. "Yes! This conversation has been *fascinating*. I…look forward to being friends with you."

Catra feels something inside her twitch. She's not looking for new friends, Entrapta can go to Scorpia for that. Maybe that will finally distract her from her aggressive attempts to befriend Catra, killing two birds with one stone.

However, she might have an opening for a new partner in crime. She has a feeling she and Entrapta could accomplish great things together.

At the very least, she'll provide entertainment to make boring shifts go by a little faster.

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